

How to Play: The Triangle Trade

Unit 1 · Mr. B's Social Studies

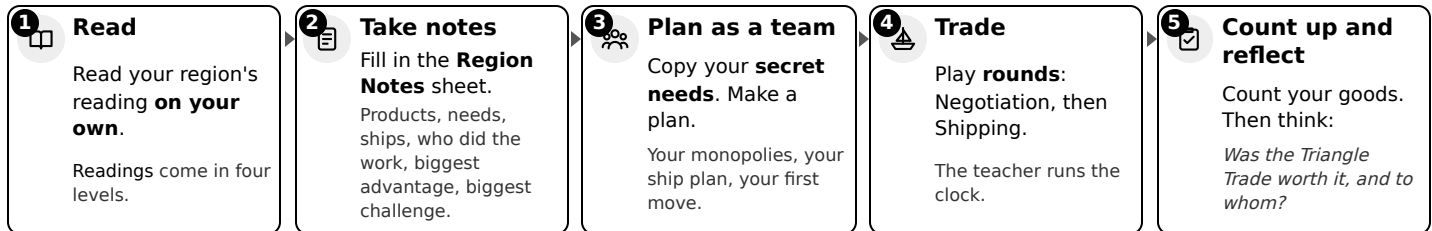
🚩 The goal

Be the **first region** to get **everything** on your **secret needs list**.

New England	Middle Colonies	Southern Colonies	West Indies	England
Boston 🚢 7 ships	Philadelphia 🚢 2 ships	Charleston 🚢 No ships	Kingston 🚢 No ships	London 🚢 8 ships

The Southern Colonies and the West Indies have **no ships**. They must **hire a ship** or **trade for one**. **Your score** = how much of your needs list you have. **Time's up and nobody finished?** The highest score wins. A tie goes to the team with **more voyages**.

The build-up: five steps



Your team's jobs

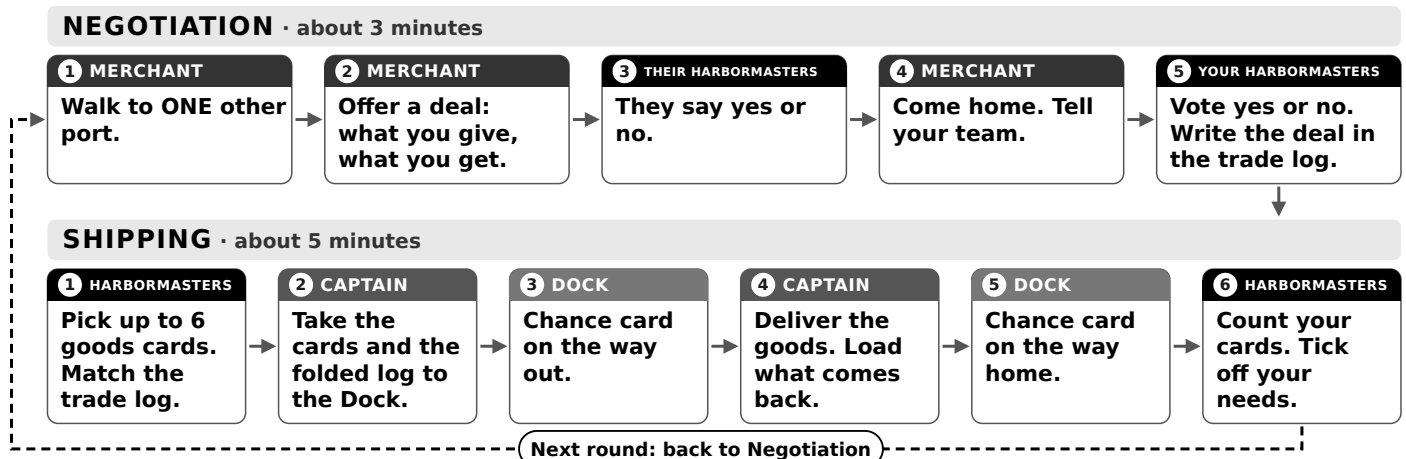
- ⚙️ Captain (1 person)**
 - Carries out the deals in **Shipping**.
 - Takes the goods cards to the **Dock**. Draws a **chance card** each way.
 - Comes back to port **quickly**.
 - 📁 Merchant (1 person)**
 - The person **in charge of trade**.
 - In **Negotiation**, visits another port to offer a deal.
 - No goods move yet. A deal counts only when your Harbormasters say **yes**.
 - ⚓ Harbormasters (everyone else)**
 - Stay at your home port** the whole game.
 - Keep the **record**. Talk with visiting Merchants.
 - Vote** on every deal. Each one also has a **Harbormaster job**.
- Big rule:** only the **Merchant** OR the **Captain** is away from port. **Never both**.

What's on your table

- Table tent:** your region's name and home port.
Goods cards: 28 cards in your region's color. **Ships are cards too**. Keep them in the bag.
Harbormaster Record, one per team. Side 1: **TOP SECRET** needs and a count of what you have. Side 2: the **trade log**.
Reading and **Region Notes** sheet, one each.
- ⚓ Harbormaster jobs**
Every Harbormaster has one. Fewer than four Harbormasters?
Double up.
- 📅 Record Keeper** Writes every deal and voyage in the **trade log** before the Captain leaves.
 - ✅ Counter** Counts the goods cards at the end of each round, fills in **"What we have"** and ticks off needs.
 - 🗨️ Port Negotiator** Meets visiting Merchants at your table and says what your team would **accept**.
 - 🚩 Strategist** Watches the board and your needs list. Decides the Merchant's **next target**.

A round, step by step

A round is **Negotiation**, then **Shipping**. Rounds repeat until the teacher calls time.



The game's Negotiation rule: "NEGOTIATION ROUND — Regions with a ship may send their merchant to one other port to propose a trade. Nothing changes hands yet — harbormasters must approve every deal."

Ships

- A ship carries **6 goods at most**, each way.
- New England, the Middle Colonies and England own ships (New England **7**, Middle Colonies **2**, England **8**).
- **No ship? Hire one:** make a deal with a team that has ships. The **fee rides as cargo**: load the goods you pay with in the hold (they count toward the 6), and they go to the ship's owner. The ship goes back to them.
- Or **trade for a ship card**. Tell the teacher at the Dock, so the game moves the ship to you.
- A ship can sail out **empty** to pick goods up, or come home empty after a delivery.

Chance cards

Two per voyage: one on the way out, one on the way home. The deck has **36** cards.

 Good news 21 of 36 ×18 Favorable Winds Nothing happens. Sail on. ×1 Free Passage! Keep it. Later it cancels one card that costs you goods. Not the Admiralty Court. ×1 Lucky Winds! Add 1 good from home to the ship. ×1 Governor's Favor Choose any port to visit next.	 Lose cargo 9 of 36 Lose 1: Storm at Sea, Sprung a Leak Lose 2: Pirates Spotted!, Bad Weather, Rough Seas, Ship Needs Repairs Lose 3: Severe Storm!, Pirates Board Your Ship!, Fire Below Deck! The Captain picks which goods.
 Pay a duty 2 of 36 ×1 Customs Inspection Pay 1 good. They go to England. ×1 British Tax Collector Pay 2 goods. They go to England.	 Admiralty Court 4 of 36 ×4 Admiralty Court! The court checks your trade log. Any mistake: England takes the whole cargo . Free Passage can't stop it.

Questions and answers

What if we don't have a ship?

Hire one or trade for one (see Ships). In Negotiation, only teams with a ship may send their Merchant out, so other Merchants will come to you.

Do we have to follow the triangle?

No. A ship can sail between **any two ports**.

Can we trade with England directly?

Yes. England is a port like the others.

Can we trade for something we don't need?

Yes. Sometimes you get a good so you can **trade it again** for something you do need.

Can the Merchant and the Captain both leave?

No. Only one of them is away from port at a time.

What if we lose goods on a chance card?

The Captain picks which goods from the ship. A **Free Passage** card can cancel it. Chance cards never take a ship.

What if the Dock's count and ours are different?

The **Dock's count is the official one**. Tell the teacher if you think it is wrong.

Why write every trade in the log?

The **Admiralty Court** can check it. A mistake means England takes the whole cargo.

What happens with rum in New England?

Follow this rule: "Rum rule: must hold 2 molasses before each 1 rum may be traded." The Harbormasters and the teacher check it.

Who wins if nobody finishes?

The team with the most of its needs list. A tie goes to the team with more voyages.

Why did the teacher stop the game?

Sometimes the teacher **pauses the game** to ask the whole class a question. That's part of the game. Each trading day also ends with a few minutes on the **standings**.

Can we tell other teams what we need?

You can, but be careful. Your needs list is **TOP SECRET**. If others know what you need most, they can ask for more.

The history behind the game

This game scores **goods**. The real Triangle Trade also traded **people**.

On the second leg of the trade, ships carried **enslaved African people** across the Atlantic Ocean by force. That crossing is called the **Middle Passage**. Many people died on the way.

The sugar, tobacco, rice and indigo in this game were grown by **enslaved people**. They were forced to work and were **never paid**.

We'll hold the game and the history together in the debrief.

Teacher notes

Pause points

- **After Round 2 on the first trading day:** press **B** (Curtain) on the Dock to cover the board, then a 2–3 minute whole-class check:
 - Which good is everyone chasing?
 - Why can't every region finish?
 - Who holds the power, and where does it come from?
- **End of each trading day:** about 5 minutes on the standings.

Likely misunderstandings, and what to say

"England always wins." / "This is unfair."

That's the point. Ask why the system favored England: a monopoly on manufactured goods, the most ships (8), and duties paid to it.

"No one will trade with us." (usually the Middle Colonies)

True to history: food and lumber were plentiful. Ask what they could carry or broker instead.

"We traded a lot, so we did well."

Trading isn't winning. The score is the share of needs secured.

"The game was fun, so the trade was good."

That's the debrief's job: the scoring left out who did the work, and the people carried on the second leg.

Debrief plan

- Open the **debrief circle** in the last ~10 minutes of the second trading day, while the results are fresh.
- The next day (short, early release) is the written **CER**: *Was the Triangle Trade worth it, and to whom?*

Rules the Dock doesn't enforce

- The rum rule ("Rum rule: must hold 2 molasses before each 1 rum may be traded."). The game shows it on New England's card but doesn't check it.
- Payment for a hired ship: **the fee rides as cargo**. Load the fee goods in the hold with the rest (they count toward the limit). If the voyage sails *to* the ship's owner, the Dock delivers the fee with everything else. If it sails somewhere else, leave the fee out of the Dock's cargo: the Captain hands those cards to the owner's port at the end of the voyage, and you move them with Log → Adjust Goods.
- A traded ship card moves only when you use Log → Transfer Ship.